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Burma under Colonial Rule

As the British completed the formal annexation of Burma, the consolidation of power would be swift. The king and his family were exiled to India. The early resistance against the British was in actuality armed gangs whose interest was much more inclined to gain material goods than to further any kind of political agenda. The initial colonial government made law and order the main priority.

It is difficult to overstate the impact the demise of the monarchy had on the Burmese psyche. The Burmese were a proud race with a distinctive ethnic identity and language with a shared history and territorial base. The throne was the essential element of centralization for the Burmese and this was shattered in 1885. The king's palace in Mandalay was transformed into an English club. The state had lost its cosmic character.

Any discussion of British control in Burma must address it in the context of the empire's policy over greater India. The British realized that is was in their best interest to subdue any surrounding areas perceived to be hostile and a threat to the economic well-being of the empire. The vast naval superiority of the British Empire, especially in the proximity of the Indian Ocean, helped to consolidate British regional hegemony.

The ease of British success stems from the collaboration attained from the Indian population. This partnership benefitted the indigenous population by providing jobs to build the infrastructure, employing industrial workers, and harvesting agricultural products such as rice. British capital financed this industrial development in areas such as mining, transportation, and plantations.

The British policy caused significant problems for the local Burmese population. The British had no knowledge of the Burmese and thus relied